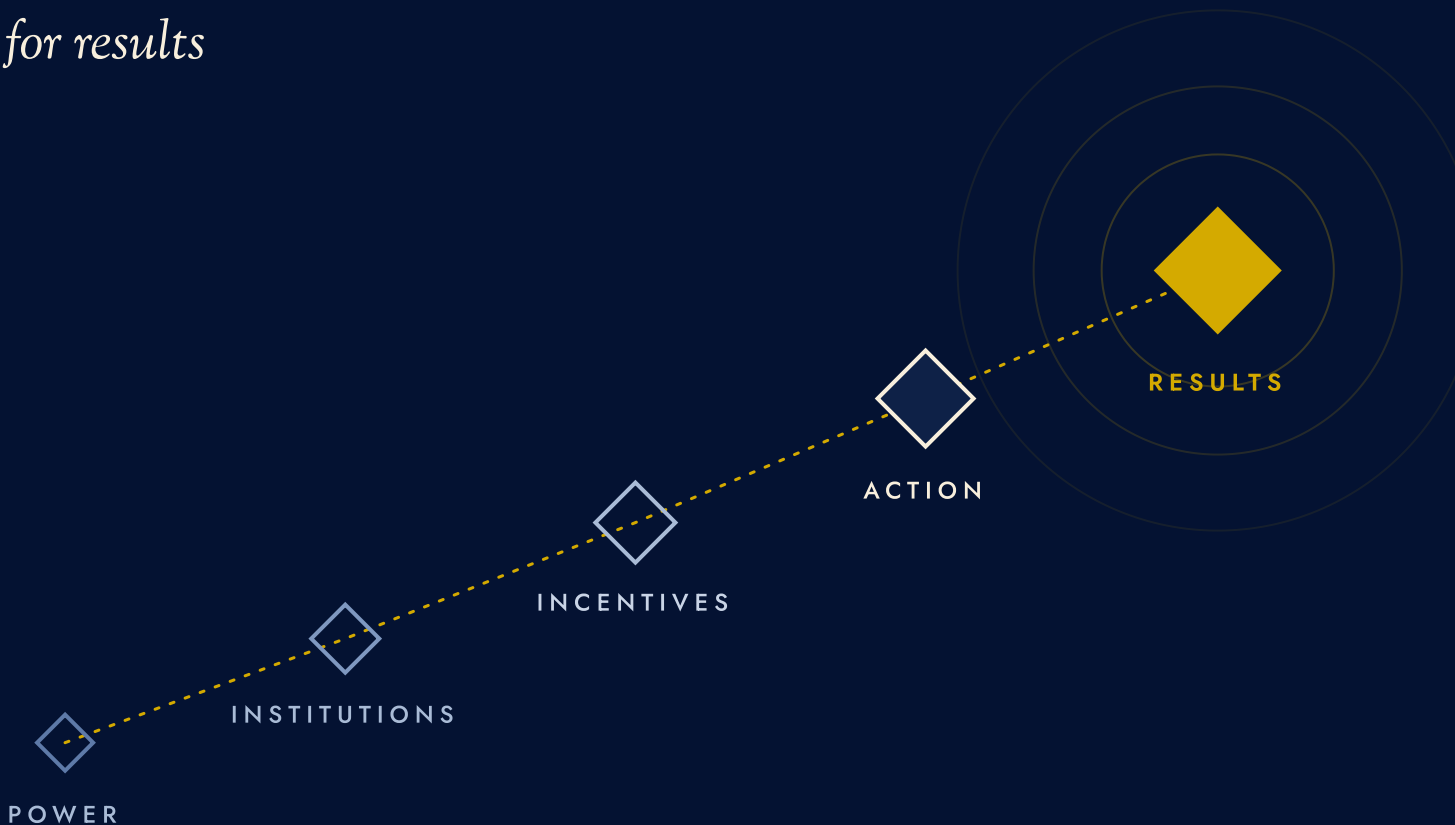




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RESULTS-BASED POLITICAL ECONOMY ANALYSIS

*From understanding power to navigating power
for results*



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Astellic
Building the future

Key definitions

The language used throughout this publication.

PEA

Political Economy Analysis

Analysis of how political and economic processes interact in a society: how power and resources are distributed and contested between groups and individuals, and the processes that create, sustain and transform those relationships over time.

Adapted from DFID (2009)

RB-PEA

Results-Based Political Economy Analysis

A problem- and results-oriented approach to political economy analysis that examines how power, interests, institutions, incentives and informal norms shape the feasibility and achievement of specific development results.

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◆ *The difference: in RB-PEA, the desired result is the unit of analysis.*

Result

The output, outcome or impact, intended or unintended, of a development intervention.

Results pathway

The causal chain from inputs through activities, outputs and outcomes to impact, with the assumptions that link each step.

Political assumption

A condition about power, interests, institutions or incentives that must hold for one link in the pathway to work.

Political gate

A point in the pathway where politics decides whether the chain holds: Authorise, Deliver, Adopt, Sustain (G1–G4).

Political feasibility

How likely an option is to be adopted, implemented and sustained, given the interests and power of those involved.

Entry point

A realistic opening for action: a decision point, coalition, institutional process or policy window.

Political economy signal

An observable change in the political context that may strengthen or weaken a gate.

Thinking and working politically

Applying political understanding throughout programme design, delivery and adaptation, not only at inception.

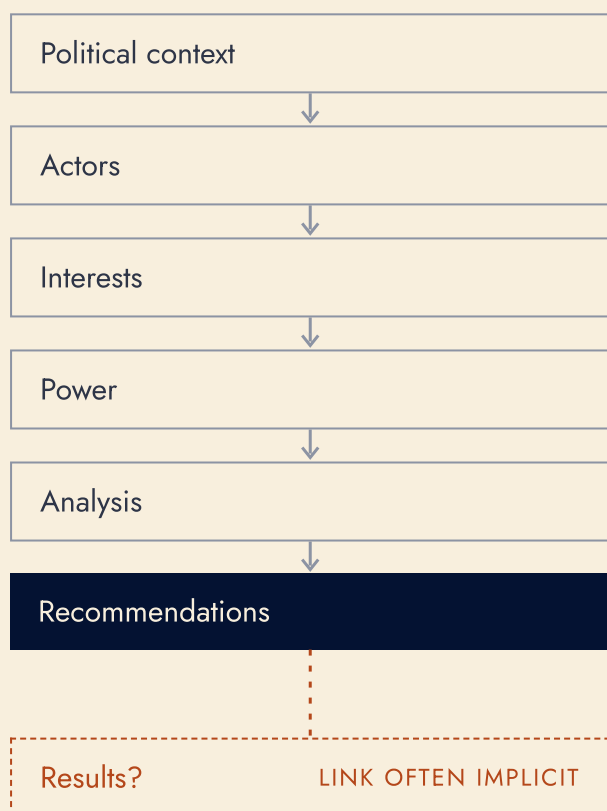
“Result” is adapted from OECD DAC (2002). Full sources on page 12.

We understand the political economy. *But do we understand what it means for results?*

Political economy analysis is now standard practice. Programmes commission it at inception, map the actors, chart the interests and name the constraints. Too often the report is then filed, while the results framework is built elsewhere, on political assumptions the analysis never tested.

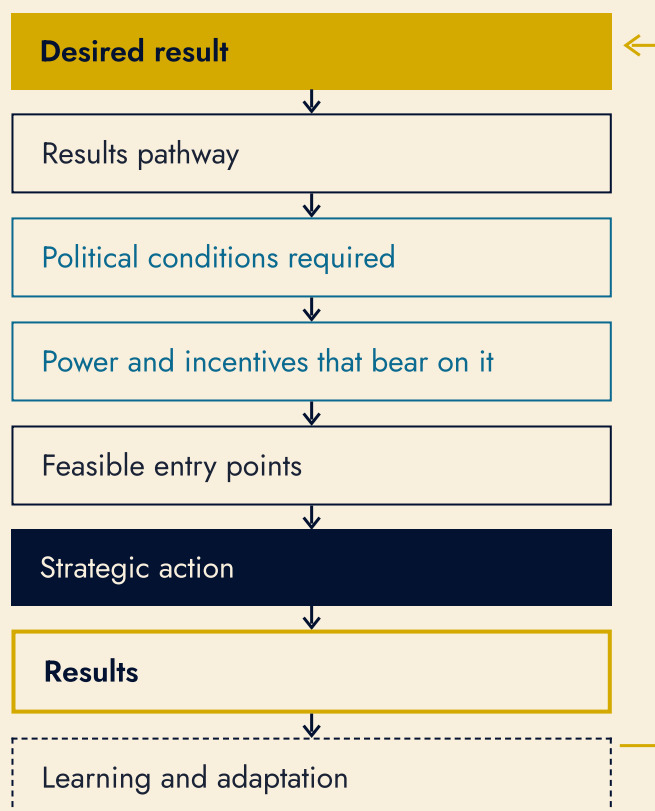
CONVENTIONAL PEA

Starts with the political system



RESULTS-BASED PEA

Starts with the result it must serve



A PEA should tell you what to do, not only what is happening.

The gap is rarely the quality of the analysis. It is the **unit** of analysis. When the political system is the starting point, results enter late, as a list of implications. When the result is the starting point, every piece of political analysis has to earn its place by explaining what helps or hinders that result.

Start with the result, *not the political system.*

RB-PEA inverts the usual sequence. Instead of describing the whole political landscape and then asking what it implies, it fixes a specific result and works backwards through the politics that will decide whether it happens.

THE RB-PEA QUESTION SEQUENCE



RESULTS LOGIC

Questions 1–2. The result and its causal pathway.

POLITICAL DIAGNOSIS

Questions 3–6. Only the politics that bears on the pathway.

DECISION

Question 7. A choice, not a list of considerations.

ADAPTATION

Questions 8–9. The analysis keeps running after design.

“

The result becomes the organising unit of political economy analysis.

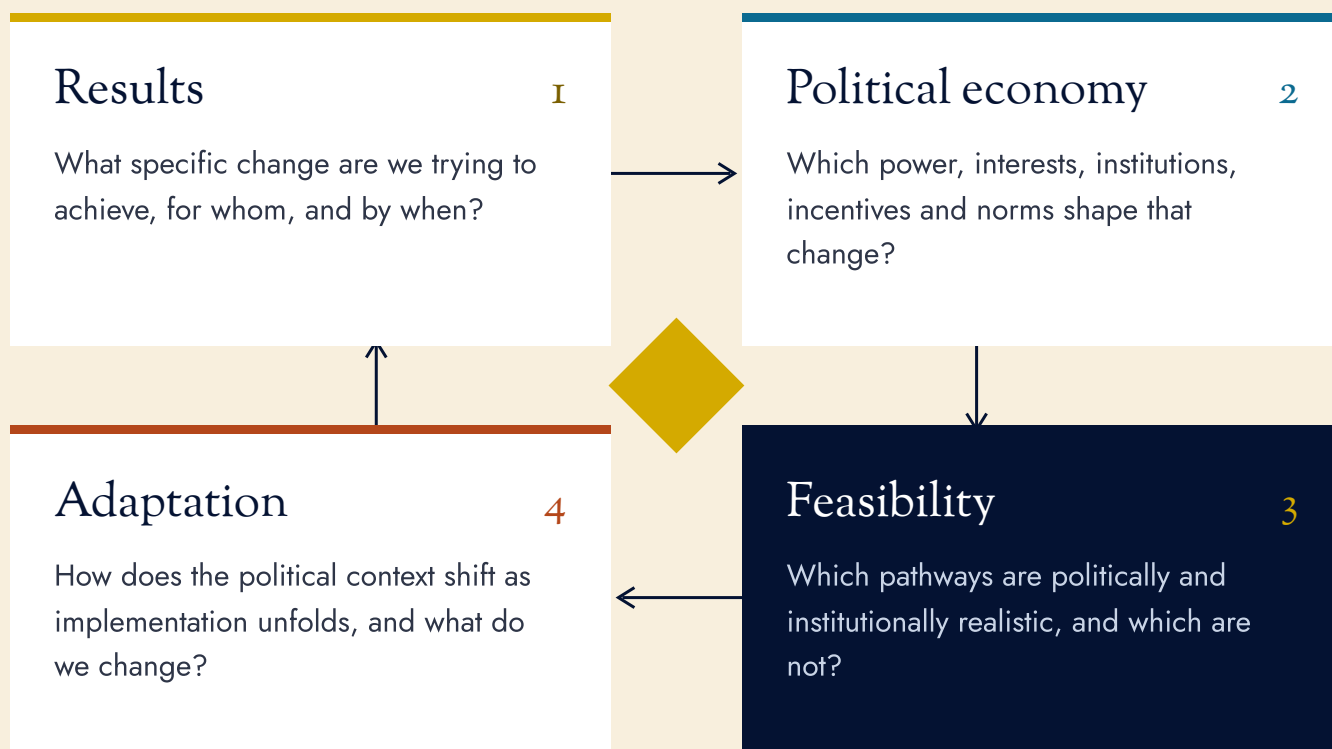
Fixing the result makes the analysis **selective** (it studies the politics that matter for this change), **testable** (its political assumptions can be monitored) and **actionable** (its findings convert into entry points).

Power matters because it changes *what is possible*.

DEFINITION

Results-Based Political Economy Analysis (RB-PEA) is a problem- and results-oriented approach to political economy analysis that examines how power, interests, institutions, incentives and informal norms shape the *feasibility and achievement* of specific development results.

FOUR FOUNDATIONAL DIMENSIONS, ONE CONTINUOUS LOOP



Three guard rails

Not PEA plus a logframe

The result reorganises the analysis. It does not sit beside it as an annex.

Not a narrowing of politics

A wide-lens check keeps structural and foundational factors in view.

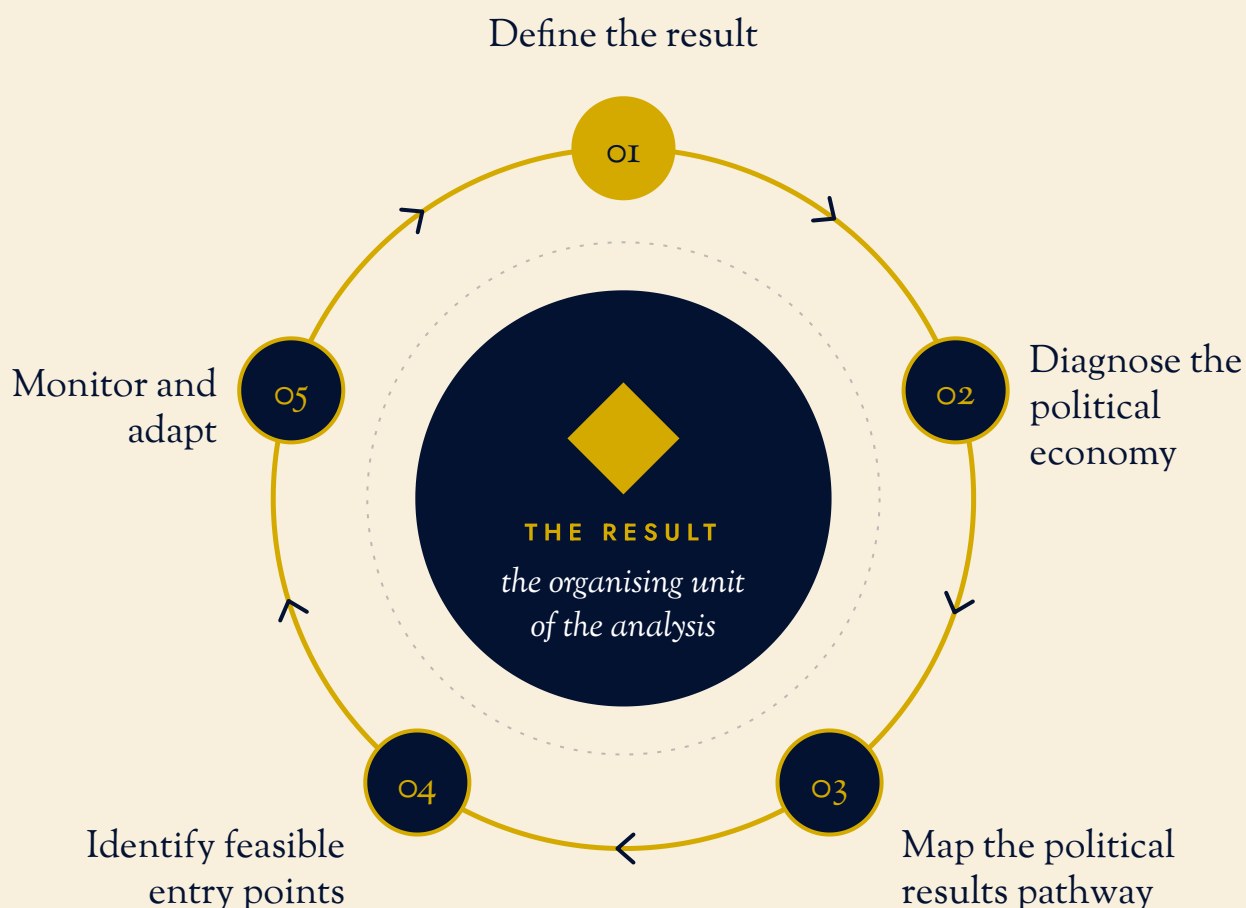
Not politically neutral

Choosing a result is itself political, so RB-PEA always asks: whose result?

ASTELLIC SIGNATURE FRAMEWORK

The RB-PEA Cycle

Five stages, organised around one result and repeated for as long as the programme runs.



RESULT > DIAGNOSE > PATHWAY > ACT > MONITOR > ADAPT > RESULT

O1	Define the result	Specify the outcome, policy change or delivery result precisely enough to reveal what it requires politically.
O2	Diagnose the political economy	Analyse the actors, interests, incentives, institutions, power and informal norms that bear on that result.
O3	Map the political results pathway	Trace the causal pathway and make explicit the political and institutional assumptions it depends on.
O4	Identify feasible entry points	Find realistic openings: influence, coalition-building, institutional change or redesign of the intervention.
O5	Monitor and adapt	Track political signals alongside results data; revise the analysis, strategy or result as conditions shift.

ASTELLIC SIGNATURE TOOL

The Political Results Pathway

Political assumptions are often the missing link in results frameworks. RB-PEA makes them visible, as four gates every result must pass through.



Orange gates mark where political conditions decide whether the chain holds.

G1 AUTHORISE

Inputs to activities

Is there a mandate, and the money, to act?

Budget actually released

Senior sign-off secured

Clear legal or administrative mandate

Staff authorised to deploy

G2 DELIVER

Activities to outputs

Will institutions cooperate to deliver?

Institutional cooperation

Resources reach the front line

Administrative authority

Leadership support holds

G3 ADOPT

Outputs to outcomes

Will anyone behave differently because of it?

Uptake by officials and users

Political ownership

Behaviour change

Incentives aligned with the result

G4 SUSTAIN

Outcomes to impact

Will it survive the next budget, election or reshuffle?

Institutionalisation

Sustained coalition support

Policy continuity

Domestic financing beyond the project

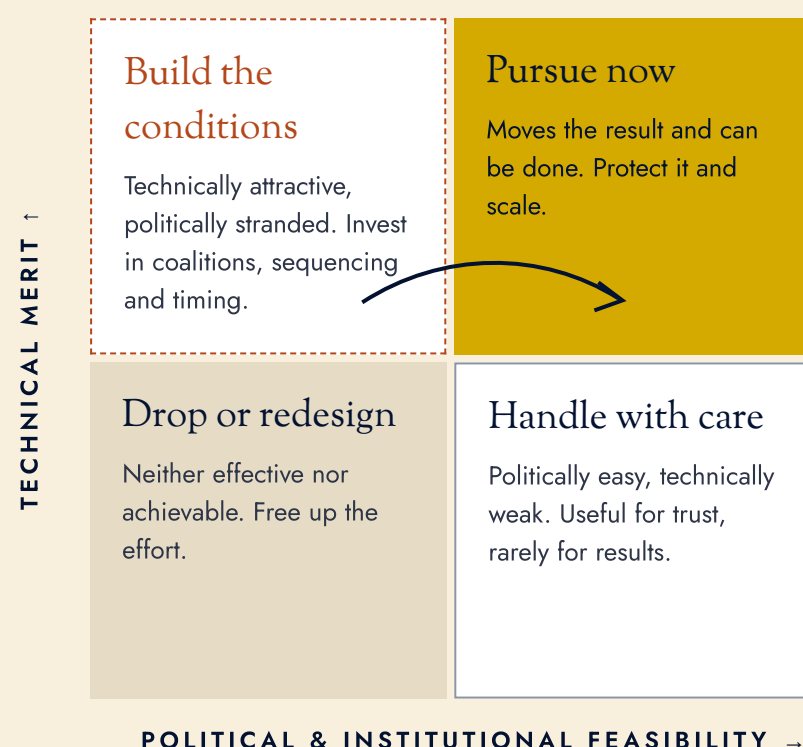
HOW TO USE IT

Write each gate condition as a testable assumption, rate how confident you are it holds, and name who controls it. The weakest gate, not the weakest activity, is usually where results fail.

From power mapping to *political feasibility*

CONVENTIONAL PEA ASKS	RB-PEA ASKS	
Who has power?	Power over what?	Power to influence which result?
	Under what conditions?	With what incentives?
	At which point in the pathway?	What can realistically change?

ASTELIC SIGNATURE TOOL / THE POLITICAL FEASIBILITY MATRIX



The most valuable move is often the arrow.

Conventional analysis tends to sort options. RB-PEA asks how a high-merit option could move from stranded to achievable: through a new coalition, a different sequence, a policy window, or a redesign that lowers what it asks of powerful actors.

The reverse matters too. A politically easy option that will not move the result is not a quick win. It is a cost.

DIMENSION	AXIS	ASSESSMENT QUESTION
Contribution to results	Merit	How much would this move the defined result?
Technical feasibility	Merit	Is it sound and deliverable with available capacity?
Political feasibility	Feasibility	Do decision-makers have reasons to support it, or to resist?
Institutional feasibility	Feasibility	Do mandates, rules and systems allow it to happen?
Stakeholder support	Feasibility	Is there a coalition strong enough to carry it?
Implementation risk	Overlay	What could reverse it, and how exposed is the result?

From actors to entry points: *what role can each actor play in the pathway to results?*

Instead of sorting actors as

supporters

opponents

influencers

beneficiaries

results-oriented stakeholder analysis asks what each can do to the result.



Enable

Create the conditions for progress: authority, budget, permission.

Which gate can they open?



Block

Veto, delay or quietly undermine progress, formally or informally.

What would change their calculation?



Influence

Shape decisions or behaviour indirectly, through ideas, networks or voice.

Whose decision do they move?



Broker

Connect competing interests and make a deal possible between them.

Who trusts them on both sides?



Legitimise

Lend political, institutional or social legitimacy to the change.

Whose endorsement makes it stick?



Implement

Convert decisions into action. Often the least consulted, most decisive.

What do they need to act?

TRACE EACH ACTOR TO THE RESULT



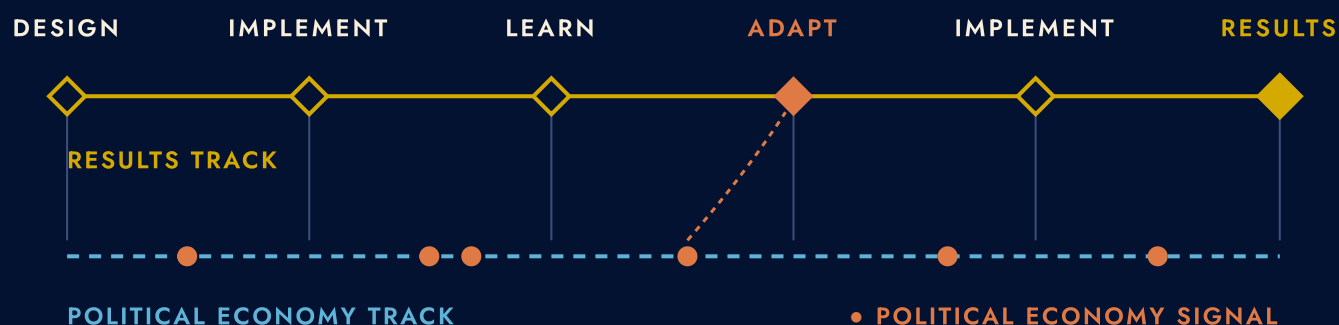
Illustrative example.

One actor, several roles.

The same ministry can enable at one gate and block at another. Map roles against gates on the pathway, not as fixed labels on actors.

A living diagnostic, *not an inception report.*

Politics moves faster than programme cycles. RB-PEA runs two tracks side by side, so that a shift in the political conditions is noticed before it shows up as a missed target.

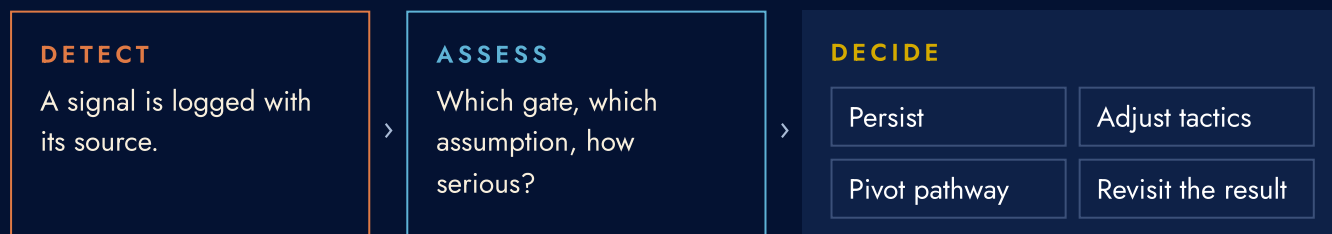


POLITICAL ECONOMY SIGNALS TO WATCH

Leadership changes	G1 G3	Policy shifts	G1 G4
Changes in institutional mandates	G1 G2	Changing donor priorities	G1 G4
Emerging coalitions	G3 G4	Bureaucratic resistance	G2
Shifts in resource allocation	G1 G2	Shifts in public or stakeholder support	G3 G4
New veto players	ANY	Implementation bottlenecks	G2 G3

Codes show the pathway gates each signal most often threatens (see page 6).

FROM SIGNAL TO DECISION



RB-PEA treats political economy as part of results management, not simply as background context.

ILLUSTRATIVE CASE / HYPOTHETICAL, NOT REAL DATA

Making decentralised primary healthcare work

RB-PEA fixes one result, then works backwards through the politics that will decide it. Each step narrows the analysis to what matters for that result, and ends in a decision.

RB-PEA TRACES ONE RESULT THROUGH ITS POLITICS

	DESIRED RESULT	District councils plan, fund and manage the primary healthcare functions transferred to them.
	POLITICAL BOTTLENECK	Functions are devolved on paper, but budgets and staff postings remain controlled centrally. The pathway stalls at G1 and G2 .
	RELEVANT ACTORS	Central finance and HR units (<i>block</i>), district executives (<i>implement</i>), the local government ministry (<i>broker</i>), councillors (<i>legitimise</i>).
	INTERESTS AND INCENTIVES	Central units keep discretion and visibility over funds. Districts fear accountability without resources. Councillors are rewarded for visible projects, not recurrent services.
	CRITICAL ASSUMPTION	Fiscal transfers follow functions within the same financial year. Untested in the original design.
	FEASIBLE ENTRY POINT	The annual budget cycle: a ring-fenced primary healthcare grant that districts manage, with light reporting that lets the centre keep oversight.
	STRATEGIC RESPONSE	Broker a joint central–local working group, pilot in a small number of districts, and publish quarterly data on transfer timeliness.
	EXPECTED RESULT	Funds reach district budgets on time. Timeliness is tracked as both a results indicator and a political signal.

What the analysis delivers. Not a description of the system, but a diagnosis: which gate is failing, whose incentives explain it, and what is worth trying first.

From analysis *to action.*

01

Makes PEA more decision-useful

02

Connects political analysis to measurable results

03

Makes political assumptions explicit and testable

04

Sharpens the search for feasible strategies

05

Enables adaptation as political conditions change

CONVENTIONAL PEA	RESULTS-BASED PEA
Understands political context	Understands what the politics means for results
Maps actors	Maps the actors that matter on the results pathway
Analyses power	Analyses how power helps or blocks change
Identifies risks	Identifies politically feasible responses
Often a point-in-time study	Iterative, tracked alongside results
Produces analysis	Supports decisions and action

The RB-PEA toolkit

Four tools, usable alone or together

PAGE 6

Political Results Pathway

Four gates that expose political assumptions.

PAGE 7

Political Feasibility Matrix

Merit against feasibility, and how to move options.

PAGE 8

Results-Oriented Stakeholder Map

Six roles, mapped against gates.

PAGE 9

Political Economy Signals Log

Signals linked to gates and decisions.

The question is no longer simply “What is the political economy?”

— The question is now:

“Given the political economy, what can realistically be achieved, and how?”

Astellic is interested in working with governments, development partners, funders and implementing organisations to apply and further develop results-based political economy approaches to complex development challenges.

Standing on established thinking

RB-PEA claims no new discipline. Its contribution is the integration, sequencing and application of these traditions around a specific result.



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